REASON AND RESPONSIBILITY

Readings in Some Basic Problems of Philosophy

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God and Morality*

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MANY PEOPLE IN OUR SOCIETY learn ethics in a religious context. A lot of parents combine ethical and religious education of children in the home, and ethical instruction is a major activity of religious institutions. So it is not surprising that many people think there is a close connection between religion and ethics. Monotheists, religious people who believe in one God, can find in their traditions support for the idea that there is such a connection. Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, which are the major forms of monotheism, all share the view that the Hebrew Bible, which Christians call the Old Testament, has religious authority. Its stories paint a picture in which ethics depends on God. Both Exodus 20:1–17 and Deuteronomy 5:6–21, which recount the revelation of the Ten Commandments, also known as the Decalogue, portray God as communicating with the human persons with whom a covenant is being established about how they ought to live their lives by issuing commands to them. It thus is natural enough to suppose that the ethical authority of the Decalogue depends on the fact that it is divinely commanded or, more precisely, on the fact that its commands express God's will.

This supposition is reinforced in the Christian New Testament. It is a striking feature of its ethics of love that love is the subject of a command. In Matthew's Gospel, Jesus of Nazareth states the command in response to a lawyer who asks which commandment is the greatest. Jesus replies: "You shall love the Lord your God with your whole heart, with your whole soul, and with all your mind. This is the greatest and the first commandment. The second is like it: You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (Matthew 22:37–39). Mark 12:29–31 tells of Jesus giving essentially the same answer to a scribe, and Luke 10:27–28 speaks of a lawyer giving this answer to a question from Jesus and being told by Jesus that it is correct. And in his last discourse to them, reported in John's Gospel, Jesus tells his followers that "the command I give you is this, that you love one another" (John 15:17). So the authors of these narratives of the life of Jesus agree that the Christian ethics of love for one another takes the form of a command. If Jesus is God the Son, as traditional Christians believe, this command has its source in and expresses the will of God.

It is therefore clear that monotheists in general, and Christians in particular, can discover deep in their sacred scriptures the roots of the philosophical position known as theological voluntarism, which is the view that ethics depends on God's will. However, as people grow up, they normally question the ethical lore they have picked up from their parents or in the synagogue, the church, or the mosque. Theological voluntarism raises many questions in modern societies, in part because such societies are becoming increasingly secular in their public culture. Must ethics have religious foundations? In Dostoyevsky's novel *The Brothers Karamazov,* the character Ivan proclaims that everything is permitted if there is no God. Ivan's

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view seems to be just what one would expect someone who thinks ethics depends on religion to hold. But it is alarming. It suggests that a decline in religious belief would bring with it catastrophic consequences for ethics. Can ethics have religious foundations? Perhaps ethics can only be securely anchored in a scientific culture if grounded or based on scientific knowledge. But this too is an alarming suggestion. Popularizations of evolutionary theory seem to tell us that evolution selects for selfish behavior and selects against unselfish behavior, except when it is directed toward close biological kin or others who are likely to reciprocate. Philosophy can help us to think clearly and rigorously about questions concerning the relations between ethics and religion. Some of those questions are the topic of this essay. Let me try to clarify the exact questions to be considered.

Up to this point in the discussion, I have spoken mainly of relations between ethics and religion. However, this way of framing the issues is too broad for a couple of reasons, one having to do with religion and the other with ethics. The concept of religion applies to many different phenomena. In advaita Hinduism, for example, the ultimate religious reality, Brahman, is an impersonal ground of being rather than a personal deity. Brahman has no will and issues no commands. Of course advaita Hinduism has a great deal to say about how people should live their lives and how, in particular, they should be related to Brahman. But its ethical teachings, though they are religious, make no appeals to divine commands. Similarly, Theravada Buddhism does not acknowledge a personal deity. It has a lot to say about how people should live in order to reach eventually the good of religious liberation, but these ethical doctrines make no reference to God's will. Theological voluntarism is not a live option within these two religious traditions. It is important to be sensitive to the variety of ethical views within the major religions of the world, but it would be impossible to do justice to all such views within the confines of a single essay. So I must focus more narrowly. My choice is to restrict my attention to the monotheistic religions, chiefly because they are the ones I know best, and to emphasize Christianity, because it is my own tradition. It should therefore be kept in mind that what I have to say simply does not apply to religious traditions that are not monotheistic.

Nor will it be possible for me to range over the whole territory of ethics. The subject matter of ethics is how people should live their lives, and it has many different parts. For example, people need certain character traits in order to live well, and so a complete ethics will contain an account of virtues and vices. A complete ethics will also address questions about the contribution of emotions to living well. Some people think that living well involves eliminating painful feelings from one's life if one can do so; others argue that someone who felt no painful sorrow upon encountering a suffering child could not be sufficiently responsive to the true nature of suffering to be living well. Among the parts of ethics, one concerns duties, actions, or refrainings from action that seem to be required from us or demanded of us. Some philosophers refer to this subdomain within ethics as morality. Thus understood, morality concerns what we must do or must not do, and so it is natural to think of ourselves as living under one or more moral laws. In order to keep the size of this essay within manageable bounds, I shall confine my attention to morality. Hence I do not aspire to present a fully general treatment of ethics and religion; instead I plan to concentrate on the connection between morality and monotheism. The theory about that connection to be investigated is theological voluntarism restricted to the moral subdomain of ethics. Following the majority of recent philosophers who have written on this topic, I shall formulate the version of theological voluntarism under consideration in terms of God's commands. So the essay's specific topic is divine command morality.

It is worth mentioning that, though divine command morality has been an important part of the history of Christian moral thought, it has competitors. In the Roman Catholic tradition, natural law morality is a prominent example. According to natural law theory, moral law is natural in the sense that it can be known by human reason apart from any revelation from God. Natural lawyers, as proponents of this view are often called, therefore

think that people who are not monotheists can have genuine moral knowledge of natural law. St. Thomas Aquinas makes this clear when he says that all people know "the common principles of the natural law" (*Summa Theologiae* I–II, 93, 2). However, Aquinas also holds that natural law is not independent of God. He tells us that "participation of the eternal law in a rational creature is called natural law" (*Summa Theologiae* I–II, 91, 2), and the eternal law is law of which God is the author. Hence, on his view, while people who are not monotheists can know the principles of natural law, they will be unaware of the ultimate source of those principles. Like divine command theory, natural law theory works with a picture of God as a legislator. Both theories are thoroughly theological in their accounts of the deepest source of morality. Because I believe that the strengths and weaknesses of theological theories of morality stand out most clearly in the case of divine command theory, I shall focus on it rather than natural law theory or other rivals within monotheistic traditions.

Having now finished explaining what lies behind my decision to include only divine command theories in this essay's treatment of God and morality, I can bring my preliminary remarks to a close. The remainder of the essay is divided into three parts. In the first, I spell out in more detail a divine command theory of morality. In the second, I mobilize some reasons monotheists can offer for accepting a theory of this kind, and in the third, I develop and try to reply to some serious objections.

I. WHAT DOES A DIVINE COMMAND THEORY CLAIM?

As it is usually understood, morality works with three main concepts; they are rightness, wrongness, and obligation. Any attempt to define all three of them in terms of the others would obvious lead to circularity. So it is best to proceed by first explaining one of them without attempting to give a definition and then defining the other two in terms of it. I begin with rightness. Morally right actions are morally permissible; they are actions that, from the moral point of view, it is all right to perform. Using the concept of rightness, it is easy to define wrongness. Actions are morally wrong if and only if they are not morally right. Morally wrong actions may be thought of as actions that morality forbids or prohibits. Moral rightness and moral wrongness are mutually exclusive categories; no action is both right and wrong. They are also collectively exhaustive categories; every action is either right or wrong. Using the concept of wrongness thus defined, a definition of obligation is simple to state. Actions are morally obligatory if and only if not performing them is morally wrong or, alternatively, not performing them is not morally right. Morally obligatory actions may be thought of as actions that morality demands or requires. Moral obligation is commonly supposed to be a subcategory of moral rightness; some actions are right but not obligatory while others are both right and obligatory. Thus, for example, when I get up in the morning, it is morally right, that is, morally permissible, for me to put my right shoe on before my left shoe. But since it is not wrong for me to put my shoes on the other way around, it is not obligatory for me to put my right shoe on before my left shoe. By contrast, when I make a serious promise and nothing weighty interferes with my keeping it, it is morally right for me to keep my promise. However, because it is wrong for me not to keep my promise, it is also morally obligatory for me to keep it. Moral obligation and moral wrongness are matters of duty. Doing one's moral duty consists of performing obligatory actions and not performing wrong actions. In effect, then, morality is a system of requirements, permissions, and prohibitions governing actions. This much is common ground for competing theories of morality.

Different theories of morality contain different principles of requirement, permission, and prohibition. According to an act utilitarian principle of prohibition, for instance, actions are morally wrong if and only if the consequences of performing them yield less utility than the consequences of performing other actions the agent could have performed instead. The principles of a divine command theory of morality can be formulated in the following way:

(1) An action is morally right if and only if (i) God does not command that it not be performed, and (ii) if it is morally right, what makes it morally right is its not being the case that God commands that it not be performed;
(2) An action is morally wrong if and only if (i) God commands that it not be performed, and (ii) if it is morally wrong, what makes it morally wrong is God's commanding that it not be performed; and
(3) An action is morally obligatory if and only if (i) God commands that it be performed, and (ii) if it is morally obligatory, what makes it morally obligatory is God's commanding that it be performed.

These three principles make precise the idea that morality depends upon divine commands and, hence, on the underlying state of God's will that such commands express.

The radical nature of this dependency becomes apparent once it is realized that the proclamation attributed to Ivan Karamazov above is a straightforward consequence of these moral principles. According to (2), an action is morally wrong only if God commands that it not be performed. But if there is no God, there are no divine commands, and so no action is such that God commands that it not be performed. Hence, if there is no God, no action is morally wrong. However, every action is either morally right or morally wrong. Thus, if there is no God, every action is morally right in the sense of being morally permissible. Similarly, nothing is morally obligatory if there is no God. For according to (3), an action is morally obligatory only if God commands that it be performed. But, again, if there is no God, there are no divine commands, and so no action is such that God commands that it be performed. Hence, if there is no God, no action is morally obligatory. In short, according to a divine command morality, if there is no God, no action is either morally wrong or morally obligatory. In other words, on such a view, if there is no God, there are no moral duties.

Does this alarming cluster of conclusions that follow directly from the principles of a divine command theory by itself provide a sufficient reason to reject those principles? I shall address this question when I respond to objections in the third part of the essay. Before I turn to that task, however, I am going to discuss some of the reasons monotheists can offer in favor of a divine command theory of morality.

II. WHY SHOULD A MONOTHEIST ACCEPT A DIVINE COMMAND THEORY?

As far as I can tell, there is no deductive argument that would count, even for monotheists, as a conclusive proof for the principles of divine command morality. However, there seems to be no such proof for any other moral theory. So perhaps the best that can be done to recommend any set of moral principles is to support them with a cumulative case argument. In such an argument, a conclusion is supported by several considerations, none of which alone is decisive but each of which helps to build the case. In this essay I shall present a cumulative case argument with four parts. They support divine command theory in a way analogous to that in which the legs of a chair support the weight of a seated person. No one leg supports all the weight, but each leg makes a contribution to supporting the weight. Three of the four parts of my cumulative case appeal to Christian traditions; the fourth draws on general considerations from philosophical theology that are shared by the major monotheisms. The point of setting forth the cumulative case is to show why adopting a divine command theory should be regarded as an attractive choice for people who are already Christians and a live option for other monotheists. The point is not to persuade people who are not already monotheists to become divine command theorists. If convincing people who are not monotheists to adopt divine command morality were my aim, I would have to start by trying to argue for the existence of God, and I do not have space in this essay for that project. Hence all I hope to get people who are not monotheists to see is why divine command morality would be a plausible option for

them if they were monotheists. I begin with the part of the cumulative case that focuses on the morality promulgated by Jesus.

Leg 1: Commanded Christian Love.

As noted above, the New Testament makes love of the neighbor the subject of a command. Is there a reason for this? I think so. It is that the love of neighbor of which Jesus speaks is very difficult for us in our present circumstances; it does not spontaneously engage our affections. If it were merely permissible, we would not love our neighbors in the way the Gospels teach. It is therefore no accident that Jesus commands love of the neighbor and thereby makes it a matter of obligation or duty.

Søren Kierkegaard has seen very clearly just how radical the demands of love of the neighbor are. In *Works of Love,* he draws a sharp distinction between erotic love and friendship, on the one hand, and Christian love of neighbor, on the other. Erotic love and friendship play favorites; Christian love of neighbor is completely impartial. Kierkegaard insists: "The object of both erotic love and friendship has therefore also the favorite's name, *the beloved, the friend,* who is loved in distinction from the rest of the world. On the other hand, the Christian teaching is to love one's neighbor, to love all mankind, all men, even enemies, and not to make exceptions, neither in favoritism nor in aversion."[1] His shocking idea is that the command to love the neighbor places absolutely everyone, including one's beloved, one's friend, and one's very self, on the same footing as one's worst enemy or people with whom one has had no contact. Perhaps it is easy to imagine God loving all humans in this undiscriminating fashion. It is hard to imagine that we would do so unless doing so were obligatory for us, for we would surely not do so spontaneously. Therefore the impartiality of Christian love of the neighbor makes that love the appropriate object of a divine command that imposes obligations on us.

According to Kierkegaard, there is another way in which love of the neighbor differs from erotic love and friendship. The latter two depend on characteristics of the beloved and the friend that can and often do change. If the beloved loses the traits that made him or her erotically attractive, erotic love withers and dies. If the friend who was prized for having a virtuous character turns vicious, the friendship will be (or at least should be) broken off. Love of the neighbor, however, is supposed to be invulnerable to such changes in its objects. Kierkegaard puts the point this way: "No change, however, can take your neighbor from you, for it is not your neighbor who holds you fast—it is your love which holds your neighbor fast. If your love for your neighbor remains unchanged, then your neighbor also remains unchanged just by being."[2] If there is to be such a love that alters not where it alteration finds, it cannot depend on changeable features of the neighbor and ways in which they engage our natural feelings and preferences. For Kierkegaard, it can have the independence it needs from such feelings and preferences only if it is obligatory, for only then can it be motivated by a stable sense of duty rather than by changeable affections.

Kierkegaard thus has at least two powerful reasons for thinking that Christian love of the neighbor must be a matter of obligation. The first is that only a love which is obligatory can be extensive enough in scope to embrace absolutely anyone without distinction. Erotic love and friendship are always discriminating and exclusive. The second reason is that only a love which is obligatory can be invulnerable to changes in its objects. Erotic love and friendship naturally and properly change in response to changes in the valued features of their objects. These reasons support the view that Christian love of the neighbor has to be a commanded love.

I think that this commanded love is foundational for Christian morality and is what sets it apart from secular rivals. The stringency of the obligation to love is apt to give offense, as Kierkegaard himself recognizes. He tries to get us to see just how demanding the obligation really is and yet to accept it as binding upon us. "Only acknowledge it," he exhorts his readers, "or if it is disturbing to you to have it put in this way, I will admit that many times it has thrust me back and that I am yet very far from the illusion that I fulfill this command, which to flesh and blood is offense, and to wisdom foolishness."[3] I agree with

Kierkegaard about the importance of highlighting rather than downplaying the stringency of the Christian obligation to love the neighbor even if, as a result of doing so, some people are thrust back or offended. But it seems to me that Christians who take the Gospels seriously are in no position to deny that they teach us that God has commanded us to love the neighbor or that this command places us under an obligation to do so. Hence I see in what is most distinctive of the Christian morality of love, the fact that it is commanded, a reason for Christians to favor a divine command theory of moral obligation.

Leg 2: Religious Practice.

According to an old saying, the law of prayer is the law of belief (*lex orandi, lex credendi*). We should probably regard this old saying as a rule of thumb rather than an exceptionless generalization, since popular devotion sometimes contains elements that are superstitious or even, as in the case of some cults, wicked. Yet often enough in Christianity, what is professed in religious practice is a good guide to what ought to be affirmed in sound theological theory. It is clear that the practice of Christian spirituality strongly emphasizes the theme of conforming one's own will to the will of God.

Janine M. Idziak has assembled numerous examples of this theme from Christian devotional sources.[4] It is found in traditional hymns such as the following: "Father, who didst fashion man/ Godlike in thy loving plan/ Fill us with that love divine/ And conform our wills to thine." It is also found in books of worship such as the Presbyterian *Daily Prayer:* "Eternal God, send your Holy Spirit into our hearts, to direct and rule us according to your will . . .", and "God of love, as you have given your life to us, so may we live according to your holy will revealed in Jesus Christ . . ." These examples, and others like them, indicate that conformity with God's will is an idea deeply embedded in Christian religious practice. Divine command principles reflect this theme at the level of moral theory. There seems to be nothing superstitious or otherwise amiss with this aspect of Christian devotional practice. Hence I think it provides some support for divine command theory in accord with the rule of *lex orandi, lex credendi.* In other words, the fact that conformity with the will of God is an important theme in Christian liturgical practices is a reason for Christians to adopt a moral theory in which divine commands that express God's will are the source of moral obligations.

I am not an expert on the religious practices of Judaism and Islam. However, I do know that traditional Judaism stresses obedience to the commands of Yahweh expressed in the Hebrew Bible. And I am also aware that Islam insists on submission to the will of Allah; indeed, the word "Islam" itself means submission (to Allah's will). So I think it safe to conjecture that Jews and Muslims have available to them arguments parallel to the argument I have just given for the case of Christianity. If this conjecture is correct, arguments of this sort will have some appeal not just for Christians but also for adherents of the other two major monotheisms.

Leg 3: The Immoralities of the Patriarchs.

A Christian tradition of interpreting some stories in the Hebrew Bible serves as the basis for an argument to the conclusion that the moral status of actions depends on divine commands. These stories recount the incidents sometimes described as the immoralities of the patriarchs. They are cases in which God commands something that appears to be wicked and, indeed, to violate a prohibition laid down in the Decalogue. Three such cases come up over and over again in Christian traditions of biblical commentary. The first is the case known as the *akedah,* the binding of Isaac, which involved a divine command to Abraham, recorded at Genesis 22:1–2, to offer his son Isaac as a sacrifice. The second is the divine command reported at Exodus 11:2, which was taken to be a command that the Israelites plunder the Egyptians. And the third is the divine command to the prophet Hosea, stated first at Hosea 1:2 and then repeated at Hosea 3:1, to have sexual relations with an adulteress. According to these stories, then, God has apparently commanded homicide, theft, and adultery (or at least fornication) in particular cases. What are we to make of these biblical tales?

The tradition of scriptural interpretation I am going to discuss takes the stories to be literally true; it supposes that God actually did issue the commands reported in the stories. It also assumes

that these commands were binding on those to whom they were addressed. In his *City of God,* St. Augustine uses the *akedah* to make the point that the divine law prohibiting killing allows exceptions, "when God authorizes killing by a general law or when He gives an explicit commission to an individual for a limited time." Abraham, he says, "was not only free from the guilt of criminal cruelty, but even commended for his piety, when he consented to sacrifice his son, not, indeed, with criminal intent but in obedience to God" (*City of God* 1, 21). Augustine thinks God explicitly commissioned Abraham to kill Isaac and then revoked the commission just before the killing was to have taken place. It is clear that Augustine believes Abraham acted as he should in consenting to kill Isaac precisely because the killing had been commanded by God. He also believes that Abraham's consent, which would have been wrong in the absence of the command, was not wrong given its presence. In other words, the divine command alone determined the moral status of Abraham's consent.

St. Thomas Aquinas shares this view. He treats the three famous cases in the following passage:

> Consequently when the children of Israel, by God's command, took away the spoils of the Egyptians, this was not theft; since it was due to them by the sentence of God.—Likewise when Abraham consented to slay his son, he did not consent to murder, because his son was due to be slain by the command of God, Who is Lord of life and death; for He it is Who inflicts the punishment of death on all men, both godly and ungodly, on account of the sin of our first parent, and if a man be the executor of that sentence by Divine authority, he will be no murderer any more than God would be.—Again, Osee, by taking unto himself a wife of fornications, or an adulterous woman, was not guilty either of adultery or of fornication: because he took unto himself one who was his by command of God, Who is the author of the institution of marriage. (*Summa Theologiae* I–II, 100, 8)

In this passage, Aquinas reasons in the following way. Because God commanded the Israelites to plunder the Egyptians, what the Israelites took on their exit from Egypt was due to them. Since theft involves taking what is not one's due, the plunder of the Egyptians was not theft. Similarly, because God, who is lord of life and death, commanded Abraham to slay Isaac, Isaac was due to receive the punishment of death all humans deserve in consequence of Adam's original sin. Since murder involves slaying someone who is not due to be slain, Abraham's consent to the slaying of Isaac was not consent to murder. And because God, who is the author of marriage, commanded Hosea to take the adulteress as his wife, she was his wife, and so he was guilty of neither adultery nor fornication in having intercourse with her. For Aquinas, therefore, the action of the Israelites was, as a result of the divine command, not really theft and so was not wrong. Similarly, because of the divine command, Abraham's consent was not consent to murder and thus was not wrong. And, on account of the divine command, Hosea's sexual intercourse was neither adultery nor fornication and hence was not wrong. In all three cases, the divine commands determined the moral status of actions; they transformed actions that otherwise would have been wrong into actions that were not wrong.

It should be emphasized that learning from Augustine and Aquinas need not be restricted to Christians who share their belief that the divine commands recounted in the biblical stories actually occurred. Some Christians may treat one or more of these cases as hypothetical rather than actual but agree with the two saints that divine commands would, if they were issued, make precisely the moral difference the saints say they actually did make. I think there would be enough agreement among Christians about these and other actual and hypothetical cases to make it reasonable to claim that Christian moral intuitions support the conclusion that God's commands determine the moral status of actions in particular cases. It also seems to me reasonable to generalize inductively from such particular cases. Hence I conclude that moral intuitions underlying the tradition of biblical interpretation to which the two saints belong provide some support for the view that the moral

status of any human action or omission depends on whether it is divinely commanded or not.

I cannot speak with authority about how the traditions of interpretation in Judaism and Islam consider it best to treat the incidents in the Hebrew Bible known as the immoralities of the patriarchs. It does seem to me, however, that Jews and Muslims could, if they wished to do so, employ the strategy of interpretation used by Augustine and Aquinas. If they do so, they will be in a position to use biblical cases to support the conclusion that the commands of Yahweh or Allah determine moral status.

Leg 4: Divine Sovereignty.

According to the doctrine of divine sovereignty, God is sovereign lord of the universe in the sense that things other than God depend on and are under the control of God. There are several reasons why monotheists of all stripes—Jews, Christians, and Muslims alike—would want to include a strong doctrine of divine sovereignty in their philosophical theology. Two of the most important pertain to creation and providence. Monotheists customarily wish to insist on a sharp distinction between God and the created world. Traditional accounts of divine creation and conservation assert that each contingent thing, which is to say each thing that might not have existed, depends on God's power for its existence whenever it exists. God, by contrast, depends on nothing outside Godself for existence. So God has complete sovereignty over the realm of contingent existence. Monotheists also usually wish to maintain that we can trust God's promises about the future and our salvation without any reservations. Even if God does not control the finest details of history because of a prior decision to create a world in which there is real indeterminism at the quantum level or libertarian free will, God has the power to ensure that the created universe will serve divine purposes for it and all its inhabitants in the long run. So God also has extensive providential sovereignty over the realm of contingent events. Our philosophical theology will have greater theoretical unity if we extend divine sovereignty from the realm of contingent existence and events to the domain of morality. Doing so will also yield a philosophical theology that is simple. Because theoretical unity and simplicity are important virtues in any theory, we want them in our philosophical theology if we can manage to get them. Adopting divine command morality would extend divine sovereignty to cover the whole domain of morality; it would give us the theoretical unity and simplicity we seek. Hence we should adopt divine command morality because doing so increases the theoretical unity and simplicity of our philosophical theology.

I think the strength of the cumulative case for divine command theory I have outlined derives in part from the diversity of sources to which it appeals. The moral demands set forth by Jesus in the Gospels, considerations drawn from sound religious practice, commentary by two saints on incidents portrayed in the Hebrew Bible, and theoretical virtues from philosophical theology all converge in supporting the adoption of divine command theory. No doubt there are other considerations within the traditions of the major monotheisms that could be added to my cumulative case, but I cannot discuss them within the limits of this essay. So I must be content to hope that the four legs of my cumulative case support its conclusion to the same extent the four legs of my office chair support my weight.

III. HOW CAN A DIVINE COMMAND THEORY BE DEFENDED?

There are many objections to divine command theory. In this respect, it is neither in better shape nor in worse shape than any other moral theory. The important question for any moral theory is how well it can be defended against the objections to it. I do not have space in this essay to consider all the objections to divine command theory, and so I must confine my discussion to the objections that my experience leads me believe many people find particularly troublesome. Since I have presented four arguments in support of divine command theory, it seems only fair for me to respond to an equal number of objections that are meant to undermine it. I shall argue that divine command

morality can be successfully defended against all four of the objections I raise. Think of each of the objections as an arrow intended to deliver a mortal wound to divine command morality. I shall try to show that none of them is a killing shot and that, taken together, they fall short of being lethal.

Arrow 1: The Karamazov Objection.

I return now to a worry I had earlier set aside. According to the theory I have formulated, if there is no God, no actions are wrong and none are obligatory. Ivan Karamazov's claim that everything is permitted or, better, is permissible is, therefore, a consequence of the theory. But why exactly is that objectionable? Perhaps it is supposed to be because Ivan's claim can be used as a premise in the following argument:

(4) If there is no God, everything is permissible.
(5) There is no God.
(6) So everything is permissible.

It is obvious that this argument is logically valid; its conclusion follows from its premises by *modus ponens*. One would hope that all decent people, whether they are monotheists or atheists, will reject its conclusion. Surely, they will insist, torturing innocent children just for one's own amusement is not morally permissible. So let us assume monotheists and atheists agree that (6) is false. Having rejected (6), they must then reject at least one of the argument's premises in order to remain consistent. Because atheists think that (5) is true, they will reject (4) and the principles of divine command theory of which it is a consequence. But monotheists can consistently accept (4) while rejecting (6) because they think (5) is false. In other words, given that (6) is false, the issue boils down to whether (5) is true and (4) is false, as the atheist holds, or (5) is false and (4) is true, as the monotheist who is a divine command theorist maintains. Without a proof of the existence of God, the divine command theorist is not in a position to show conclusively that (5) is false and the atheist is mistaken. But, equally, without a proof of the nonexistence of God, the atheist is not in a position to show conclusively that (5) is true and the divine command theorist is mistaken. It is generally agreed that none of the known arguments for or against the existence of God amounts to a proof. That being so, not being backed up by a proof of the nonexistence of God, this objection by itself does not yield a refutation of divine command theory.

Arrow 2: The Moral Skepticism Objection.

It is sometimes thought that divine command theory implies moral skepticism. An argument for this view might take the following form. According to divine command theory, we can come to know what is morally obligatory or wrong only by first coming to know what God has commanded. Hence only people who have religious knowledge can have moral knowledge. But no one actually has religious knowledge of what God has commanded. As Eric D'Arcy notes, "if immoral actions are immoral merely because God so wills it, merely because God legislates against them, it would be sheer coincidence if someone who knew nothing of God or his law happened to adopt the same views about particular actions as God did."[5] Mere coincidence of our views with God's views, however, would not give us religious knowledge of God's views, though it would yield true beliefs about them, because true beliefs are not sufficient for knowledge. Thus we could not derive moral knowledge from such true beliefs about God's views. And the best we can hope for when the subject is God's views is true beliefs. Even if some religious people have them, this is a matter of faith rather than knowledge. In sum, for divine command theory, the only route we have to moral knowledge is through religious knowledge of God's commands, and this route is blocked because our only access to God's commands is through faith which, while it may yield true beliefs about divine commands, is bound to fall short of producing knowledge.

One way the divine command theorist can reply to this objection is simply to assert that scripture, religious traditions, and personal religious experience can be sources of knowledge about what God commands. Though I tend to think this is true, I do not find it a convincing response. The objector

can easily cast doubt on it by pointing to the sharp disagreement among religious people themselves about what those sources deliver. They quarrel about how to interpret scripture, which of the competing religious traditions preserves genuine revelation from God, and whose religious experiences are veridical.* Can such sources yield knowledge when they give rise to controversy of this sort? There is, however, a better response available to the divine command theorist. The theory asserts that God's commands make it the case that certain actions are morally obligatory and others are wrong. It makes no epistemological claims, and, in particular, it makes no claims about how we might come to know what God has commanded. It does not imply that we can come to know what is morally obligatory or wrong only by first coming to know what God commands. In other words, the subject matter of divine command theory is a certain kind of metaphysical dependency of morality on God's commands. But the order of epistemological access to things can be the reverse of the order of metaphysical dependency. Causation provides an example from ordinary life. Though effects are metaphysically dependent on their causes, we often come to know causes by first coming to know their effects. So it is not a consequence of divine command theory that only people who have religious knowledge can have moral knowledge; the divine command theorist can consistently deny that our only route to moral knowledge is through religious knowledge. Therefore, the objection fails.

Indeed, the divine command theorist could consistently hold that we can only come to know what God's commands are by first coming to know what is morally obligatory or wrong. Jeremy Bentham, who was a utilitarian, once expressed a view of this kind. He said: "We may be perfectly sure, indeed, that whatever is right is conformable to the will of God: but so far is that from answering the purpose of showing us what is right, that it is necessary to know first whether a thing is right, in order to know from thence whether it be conformable to the will of God."[6] As this remark suggests, Bentham apparently thought that a moral theory would be useless unless it answered to the purpose of showing us what it right. It must be granted to Bentham that divine command theory does not answer to the purpose of showing us what is morally obligatory, permissible, and wrong if we can only come to know to know what God's commands are by first coming to know what is morally obligatory, permissible, and wrong. In that case, divine command theory would not provide us with a decision procedure for morality, a way of deciding or determining the moral status of an action. But so what? It is not obvious that failure to provide a decision procedure is a fatal flaw in a moral theory. Presumably it would be of theoretical interest to learn that what is morally obligatory, permissible, and wrong depends on God's commands, even if this knowledge were by itself of no practical use. In fact, it seems to be the case that Bentham's own utilitarianism runs into a similar difficulty. No one is in a position to calculate and assign numeral utility values to all the consequences of all the alternative actions open to the agent in many circumstances in which moral decisions must be made. When this is pointed out to utilitarians, some of them respond that it would be of theoretical interest to learn that utilitarianism is true, even if applying it to get solutions to urgent moral problems is often not a practical possibility. It would hardly be fair for utilitarians who use this response to defend their theory to object if divine command theorists say similar things in defense of their theory.

Arrow 3: The Divisiveness Objection.

Another objection to divine command theory is that it is bound to be a divisive position. William K. Frankena develops the idea this way:

> However deep and sincere one's own religious beliefs may be, if one reviews the religious scene, one cannot help but wonder if there is any rational and objective method of establishing any religious belief against the proponents of other religions or of irreligion. But then one is impelled to wonder also if there is anything to be gained by insisting that all ethical principles are or must be logically grounded on

*[i.e., accurately conveying the truth]

> religious beliefs. For to insist on this is to introduce into the foundation of any morality whatsoever all of the difficulties involved in the adjudication of religious controversies, and to do so is hardly to encourage hope that mankind can reach, by peaceful and rational means, some desirable kind of agreement on moral and political principles.[7]

Though Frankena is in these remarks discussing views in which the relation between religion and morality is supposed to be a matter of logic, presumably he would have a similar worry about our divine command theory in which the relation is metaphysical. And, of course, Frankena is quite correct in pointing out that religious disagreement has in the past given rise to sharp moral disagreement and continues to do so in our own times. Still, there are three things worth saying in response to his worry.

First, religious disagreement does not inevitably lead to disagreement about moral principles. A divine command theorist can agree with a Kantian moral theorist who is not religious on the principle that torturing the innocent is always morally wrong. They will, to be sure, disagree about why torture of the innocent is always wrong. A divine command theorist will say that it is wrong because God has commanded that no one ever torture an innocent person. A secular Kantian may say that it is wrong because, involving as it does a failure to treat humanity in another person as an end in itself, it violates the categorical imperative. Disagreement at the deepest level of moral theory is therefore consistent with agreement at the level of moral principles. So despite religious disagreement, there are grounds for hope that we can reach, by peaceful and rational means, an overlapping consensus on at least some moral and political principles.

Second, not all moral disagreement is divisive. A Kierkegaardian Christian may think that Mother Teresa was only doing her duty toward her neighbor as specified by the Love Commandment in the Gospels, when she devoted herself to caring for wretched people in India, and regret the failure of the rest of us to satisfy her high standard of duty. One of her secular admirers may believe that much of the good she did was supererogatory, that is, above and beyond the call of duty. But if they agree that she did a great deal of good for others and that the earth would be better off if it had on it more people like her in this respect, their disagreement about whether some of her good works were obligatory or supererogatory is not apt to be especially divisive.

Yet, third, in spite of the fact that disagreement about religion is likely to lead to less moral disagreement than one might initially have imagined, it seems utterly unrealistic to expect agreement on all matters of moral and political principle as long as disagreement in moral theory persists. However, as Robert M. Adams has pointed out, nothing in the history of modern secular moral theory gives us reason to expect that general agreement on a single comprehensive moral theory will ever be achieved or that, if achieved, it would long endure in a climate of free inquiry. As any student who has taken a course in moral philosophy can testify, it is a subject chock full of combat between rival moral theories. The conclusion Adams draws, with which I agree, is that "the development and advocacy of a religious ethical theory, therefore, does not destroy a realistic possibility of agreement that would otherwise exist."[8] In other words, if those who accept divine command theory advocate it, they will not make the situation of disagreement worse. Moreover, if they refrain from advocating it, they will forfeit an opportunity to make the situation better. For if divine command theory is not advocated, it will not be subject to testing by public critical scrutiny in the marketplace of ideas. And if it is not tested in such debates, we will never discover whether there are reasons for rejecting it or grounds for accepting it above and beyond those we already have. So if divine command theory is not advocated, we will never get any closer than we are now to knowing whether or not it is true. But if it is advocated, there is at least a chance that we will, as a result of public debate, come closer to knowing whether or not it is true. Hence if those who accept divine command theory advocate it, we will not be made intellectually worse off and we may become intellectually better off. Therefore, even if it is granted, as I think it should be, that di-

vine command theory is, to some extent, a divisive point of view, there are still good reasons of a practical sort to favor its advocacy and development. And it is worth noting that, despite his worry about the divisiveness of linking morality to religion, Frankena himself acknowledges that if the view that morality is dependent on religion rests on good grounds, we must accept it.[9]

Arrow 4: The Euthyphro Objection.

The most powerful objection to divine command theory is often traced back to classical antiquity. In the dialogue *Euthyphro,* Plato has Socrates ask Euthyphro to consider the following question. "Is what is pious loved by the gods because it is pious, or is it pious because it is loved" (*Euthyphro* 10a)? Some of the discussion in the dialogue turns on special features of the polytheism of Greek popular religion. For example, Socrates suggests that the gods might disagree about piety, some of them loving it while others hate it, and he persuades Euthyphro that perhaps in that case there would be things that are both pious and impious. What Socrates suggests does seem to be a real possibility for the quarrelsome gods portrayed in the epic poetry of Homer, but it obviously is not a possibility for monotheists. So the question needs to be rephrased if it is to be addressed to monotheists.

A question monotheists who believe that God does issue commands must confront is this: Are actions commanded by God because they are obligatory, or are actions obligatory because they are commanded by God? And there is, of course, a similar question about wrongness and being contrary to the commands of God. Such questions seem to impale divine command theorists on the horns of a dilemma. On the one hand, if actions are commanded by God because they are obligatory, then such actions are obligatory prior to and independent of being divinely commanded. But divine command theorists cannot accept the view that actions are obligatory independent of being divinely commanded. It is not consistent with their view that divine commands make actions obligatory; actions that are made obligatory by divine commands are not obligatory independent of those commands. It also undercuts one of the legs in the cumulative case for divine command theory, since actions that are obligatory independent of God's commands are not actions over whose moral status God has sovereignty. On the other hand, however, if actions are obligatory because they are commanded by God, then it at any rate seems that obligation is completely arbitrary, because God could, just by commanding it, make any action whatsoever obligatory and, hence, no matter how horrendous an action might be, it would be obligatory if God were to command it. In the seventeenth century, Ralph Cudworth pressed this objection to divine command morality in particularly vivid and forceful language. He wrote:

> divers Modern Theologers do not only seriously, but zealously contend . . . , <u>That there is nothing Absolutely, Intrinsically, and Naturally Good and Evil, Just and Unjust, antecedently to any positive command of God; but that the Arbitrary Will and Pleasure of God</u>, (that is, an Omnipotent Being devoid of all Essential and Natural Justice) <u>by its Commands and Prohibitions, is the first and only Rule and Measure thereof</u>. Whence it follows unavoidably that nothing can be imagined so grossly wicked, or so foully unjust or dishonest, but if it were supposed to be commanded by this Omnipotent Deity, must needs upon that Hypothesis forthwith become Holy, Just and Righteous.[10]

Does the divine command theorist have anything to say in response to Cudworth's stinging indictment?

In order to address this question, I must introduce a new idea into the discussion. Up to this point, I have been working exclusively with the moral categories of rightness, wrongness, and obligation, but now I want to bring onto the scene another pair of ethical categories, goodness and badness. Monotheists have traditionally held that God is perfectly good. Putting this point in a way Plato might find congenial, God is the Good itself, and creatures are good only in virtue of resembling God in some respect. In the account of creation in Genesis 1, humans are said to have been made in the image and likeness of God. Monotheists might generalize from this story and say that creatures

resemble God by bearing the relation of imaging to God. It is worth noting that this view does not make goodness independent of God and thus does not compromise the doctrine of divine sovereignty. After all, if God does not exist, then, on this view, the Good itself, the paradigm of goodness, does not exist either, and so nothing other than God is good because nothing bears the relation of imaging to a paradigm that does not exist. The divine command theorist can use this view of divine goodness as the basis of a reply to Cudworth.

Consider some state of affairs we are certain is foully unjust, say, an innocent child being tortured to death. Cudworth's complaint is that divine command theory has as a consequence the following conditional or hypothetical statement:

(7) If God commands someone to torture an innocent child to death, then it is morally obligatory for that person to torture the child to death.

And Cudworth is correct about this point because (7) does follow from (3). However, a refutation of divine command theory can be derived from this point only if it can be shown that (7) is false, and the divine command theorist is in a position to argue that (7) is, in fact, true. Since God is the Good itself, divine goodness constrains what God commands or, indeed, even could command. God never commands anyone to torture an innocent child to death, and so the antecedent of (7) is false. But according to elementary logic books, conditionals with false antecedents are themselves true. Hence, by the divine command theorist's lights, (7) is true. In short, God's commands are not arbitrary. So the fact that (7) follows from divine command theory is not really a problem because it is open to the divine command theorists to grant that (7) is true.

Can this reply to Cudworth be generalized from the example of torturing an innocent child to death, and others like it, to cover all cases? Maybe not. Monotheists typically hold that God is a transcendent being. God's infinite goodness is not exactly the same as finite human goodness; they are, it is sometimes said, only analogous. God's goodness is therefore, at least to some extent, beyond our ken; we cannot completely grasp it; it is bound to remain, in some ways, incomprehensible to us. This does not mean that we could or should be prepared to accept as good a set of alleged divine commands that is totally contrary to our human ideas of goodness. It does, however, leave room for the possibility that there are a few divine commands that violate our assumptions about goodness. In order to face up to this possibility, let us return to the biblical story of the *akedah*.

In order to get a grip on what this story might mean for us, Robert M. Adams asks us to imagine a modern Abraham who at first finds overwhelmingly plausible all three of the following claims:

(8) If God commands me to do something, it is not morally wrong for me to do it.
(9) God commands me to kill my son.
(10) It is morally wrong for me to kill my son.[11]

Since the negation of (10) follows by *modus ponens* from (8) and (9), these claims are inconsistent, and Adams stipulates that his Abraham recognizes their mutual inconsistency. The question then becomes which of (8)–(10) it would be best for Abraham to reject. It would not be easy for a divine command theorist to endorse rejecting (8). By (3), if God commands Abraham to kill his son, it is obligatory for him to do it. Given the supposition, mentioned above, that obligation is a subdomain of rightness, if it is obligatory for Abraham to kill his son, it is right and hence not wrong for him to do it. And so, by the logical law known as the transitivity of implication, if God commands Abraham to kill his son, it is not wrong for him to do it. Thus Abraham's choice boils down to rejecting (9) or rejecting (10). Confronted with this choice, Abraham gets conflicting advice from two great modern philosophers.

Kant's advice is to reject (9), and Adams favors this option. In a famous passage in *The Conflict of the Faculties,* he tells Abraham precisely what he ought to do. Kant writes: "Abraham should have replied to this supposedly divine voice: 'That I ought not to kill my good son is quite certain. But that you, this apparition, are God—of that I am

not certain, and never can be, not even if this voice rings down to me from (visible) heaven.'"[12] Perhaps the plausibility of Kant's position can be made clearer with the help of a thought experiment. Imagine you have just moved into a new house and, looking out the kitchen window, you spot your next door neighbor building a stone altar in his back yard. When you ask what it is for, he tells you he has been commanded by God to sacrifice his son, and he cordially invites you to drop by in the morning and take part in the ceremony. Surely your first reaction would be to think that your new neighbor ought to in a mental hospital. Yet, though I acknowledge the force of such considerations, I do not believe they are decisive. If I did, my earlier argument that incidents resembling the *akedah* can be part of a cumulative case for divine command theory would be seriously undermined. But I do not believe that it is undermined, because I think Kant's claim that Abraham could never be certain that God had commanded him to kill his son can be successfully challenged. According to monotheists, God is, as Cudworth mentioned, omnipotent. It is therefore within God's power to give Abraham a sign that would make him certain that he has been commanded to kill his son. Suppose, for example, that one night, in the twinkling of an eye, the stars in the sky are rearranged to spell out the sentence "ABRAHAM, SACRIFICE ISAAC!" Abraham observes this transformation of the heavens. Observers all over the world, some of whom do not even know English, testify that they now see this pattern in the night sky, and Abraham learns of this testimony and uses it to rule out the possibility that he is hallucinating. Being a modern person, he reasons that the stellar rearrangement he observed could not have occurred without many of the stars achieving velocities in excess of the speed of light and thereby miraculously violating a law of physics. In such circumstances, it seems to me, Abraham would be crazy not to believe that he had been divinely commanded to kill his son and would be certain if he believed it.

In a case of this sort, I think Abraham's best bet would be to reject (10) and to suppose that what Kierkegaard calls a teleological suspension of the ethical occurs. In *Fear and Trembling,* which he published under the pseudonym of Johannes de Silentio, Kierkegaard concludes that "the story of Abraham contains therefore a teleological suspension of the ethical."[13] It is a suspension of the ethical or, in the idiom of this essay, a suspension of the moral because God exempts Abraham from a moral principle that would otherwise be binding on him. In the circumstances, therefore, it is not wrong for Abraham to kill his son. The suspension is teleological because God suspends the moral in order to achieve a special goal (*telos*). According to Kierkegaard, God's goal in the *akedah* is to subject Abraham to a severe test of the depths of his faith, a test which Abraham passes. It is worth pointing out that the teleological suspension of the ethical plays the same role in Kierkegaard's thought about Abraham that the notion of a commission from God to an individual for a limited time plays in Augustine's thought and that the concept of being an executor of a death sentence by divine authority plays in Aquinas' thought. In all three cases, the general idea is that God can, in particular instances, create exceptions to or exemptions from moral principles that would otherwise be in force. I think divine command theorists ought to allow for the possibility of such divinely mandated exceptions or exemptions. If they do, they will be in a position to use the immoralities of the patriarchs as part of a cumulative case for divine command theory.

It does not follow from this view that divine command theorists must concede to Cudworth or, more generally, to the Euthyphro objection that God's commands are or could be completely arbitrary. So a divine command theorist can respond to the charge of arbitrariness by saying that actions are obligatory because God commands them and yet God's commands are not and could not be completely arbitrary because they are constrained by God's goodness. What must be conceded is that God's commands need not always conform to our ideas of goodness. I reckon that it is safe enough for monotheists to make this concession. To demand that God conform to our ideas would be to make our ideas rather than their transcendent object an absolute, and monotheists will rightly fear

that absolutizing anything finite, including our ideas, would be a form of idolatry.

But divine command theorists must concede something to Cudworth. According to his complaint, divine command theory has among its consequences another conditional or hypothetical statement that is every bit as unattractive as (7). It is this:

(11) If God commands Abraham to kill his son, then it is morally obligatory for Abraham to kill his son.

And Cudworth is right on this point too because (11) does follow from (3). If divine command theorists do not imitate Kant in rejecting (9), they will be committed to holding that the antecedent of (11) is true. According to the logic books, however, the only way for (11) as a whole to be true, as the divine command theorists must insist that it is, when its antecedent is true, is for its consequent also to be true. So a Kierkegaardian divine command theorist is committed to holding that it is morally obligatory for Abraham to kill his son. Having rejected (10), the Kierkegaardian divine command theorist can consistently maintain that it is morally obligatory, and hence morally right and so not morally wrong, for Abraham to kill his son. People like Cudworth are sure to think such claims outrageously false. At this point, the Kierkegaardian divine command theorist has no choice except to bite the bullet and disagree with such people. It seems to me there is nothing amiss if the Kierkegaardian divine command theorist insists that they are true.

Having shown that divine command theory is not refuted by any one of the four objections I have considered, let me conclude by asking whether, taken together, they add up to much of a cumulative case against it. In other words, given that none of the individual arrows directed against divine command theory delivers a mortal wound, how badly is it wounded, if at all, by all of them together? In my opinion, the second and third arrows simply miss the mark. Because the divine command theory I have formulated makes no epistemological claims, it has no epistemological consequences, and so it cannot be faulted for having false or unwarranted epistemic implications. And one cannot view the fact that there will be disagreement about it as a good reason to reject it unless one is also prepared in fairness to regard disagreement as a good reason to reject all known philosophical theories in morality, in ethics more generally and in politics, not to mention all known theories in a host of other areas of philosophy. However, I do admit that the first and fourth arrows hit their target, though I do not think that, either separately or together, they do lethal damage. The existence of evil, after all, does count to some extent, but not decisively, as evidence against monotheism, and so, for those who deny that everything is permissible, it provides a reason, though not, it seems to me, a conclusive reason, for accepting the antecedent of (4) and hence rejecting (4) and the principles of divine command theory of which it is a consequence. And while I think a teleological suspension of the ethical is possible and may even have occurred on a few occasions, I recognize that many people will find the claim that Abraham is or even could be under a moral obligation to kill his son, and similar claims in other cases, intuitively very implausible. So I am certainly prepared to allow that there is a cumulative case against divine command theory that has some real force.

After being examined, then, divine command theory winds up with both pluses and minuses on its score card. Monotheists can support it with a cumulative case argument, but there are also considerations adding up to a cumulative case argument that goes some way toward undermining it. Neither argument comes anywhere close to being a definitive proof of the sort one discovers in logic books. In this respect, divine command theory is just like all the other moral theories currently debated in philosophy. Each of them is such that there is no knock-down, drag-out argument for it and also no such argument against it. In a way, this is a frustrating situation; in another way, it is challenging. There is still an opportunity, which will excite people who enjoy doing philosophy, to join the search for arguments for or against moral theories that are stronger and more conclusive than any yet known to us. Perhaps this essay will stimulate some of its readers to take advantage of that opportunity.[14]

NOTES

1. Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*. Trans. H. V. Hong and E. H. Hong (New York: Harper, 1964), p. 36.

2. *Ibid.*, p. 76.

3. *Ibid.*, p. 71.

4. Janine M. Idziak, "Divine Command Ethics," *A Companion to Philosophy of Religion*. Ed. P. L. Quinn and C. Taliaferro (Oxford: Blackwell, 1997), pp. 453–459. The two examples I quote come from p. 457.

5. Eric D'Arcy, "Worthy of Worship: A Catholic Contribution," *Religion and Morality*. Ed. G. Outka and J. P. Reeder, Jr. (Garden City, NY: Anchor, 1973), p. 194.

6. Jeremy Bentham, *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation* (New York: Hafner, 1948), p. 22.

7. William K. Frankena, "Is Morality Logically Dependent on Religion?" *Religion and Morality*. Ed. G. Outka and J. P. Reeder, Jr. (Garden City, NY: Anchor, 1973), p. 313.

8. Robert M. Adams, "Religious Ethics in a Pluralistic Society," *Prospects for a Common Morality*. Ed. G. Outka and J. P. Reeder, Jr. (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1993), p. 91.

9. Frankena, *op. cit.*, p. 314.

10. Ralph Cudworth, *A Treatise Concerning Eternal and Immutable Morality* (New York: Garland, 1976), pp. 9–10.

11. Robert M. Adams, *Finite and Infinite Goods: A Framework for Ethics* (New York and Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), p. 280. I have renumbered Adams' sentences.

12. Immanuel Kant, *The Conflict of the Faculties*. Trans. M. J. Gregor and R. Anchor, in Kant, *Religion and Rational Theology*, ed. A. W. Wood and G. di Giovanni (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), p. 283.

13. Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, in Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling and the Sickness unto Death*. Trans. W. Lowrie (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1968), p. 77.

14. Some of the material in this essay is discussed in greater technical detail in Philip L. Quinn, "Divine Command Theory," *The Blackwell Guide to Ethical Theory*. Ed. H. LaFollette (Oxford: Blackwell, 2000), pp. 53–73.